Because she and Jackie—Victoria's mum—are the world's best babysitters, I was still seeing a lot of my mum around the time things started to go wrong for me at United. I've always known that she and Dad were there for me but, as far as soccer was concerned, Mum had given me support while Dad, I suppose, had been the one to give me guidance. Now, though, she could see for herself how this standoff with the boss was torturing her son; and how me being upset was hurting her daughter-in-law and her grandchildren too. Without me knowing, Mum decided to take it on herself to do something about what was happening.

We played West Ham in the FA Cup and Mum was at Old Trafford to watch. For the first time, I felt the depression affecting my game. I played, and we won 6–0, but there wasn't much pleasure to be gotten from it, especially as the boss had had a go at me about something at half-time. I remember getting changed and leaving the ground as quick as I could. By the time I was in the car with Victoria, it felt like something had to give. I felt completely powerless and just sat there, staring out into the rain, and choking back the tears. Mum came away from Old Trafford a bit later—she and Joanne were driving back to London separately—and phoned from their car:

'I've been to see him.'

My first reaction was: 'Been to see who?'

Without Mum saying, I knew she meant the boss. And then I was angry. The idea of my mum going to see my boss seemed totally wrong, somehow. She explained that it hadn't been planned, that she'd run into the manager by chance in the corridor and felt she had to tell him what she thought. At 27, it seemed to me that I should be able to sort out my own problems at work. It was a real surprise to me that she'd done what she had. I'd guess it was for the boss, too. She told me a bit about what had been said and one thing stuck in my mind:

'Do you know Sandra, the trouble with David is that everybody sucks up to him now.'

Nothing the manager could have said about me could have hit harder than that. I've always believed, whatever anyone else says or thinks about you, that you have to be true to yourself. When I was a kid—playing for Ridgeway, training with Spurs, starting out at United—whenever Dad had been angry with me about something, had decided my attitude wasn't right, he'd known just what to say to really get to me: